Names, organisations, locations, dates, figures and other identifying details have been redacted or generalised. The commercial findings and recommendations are unchanged.

HALF-TIME TEAM TALK

OWNER-RUN SERVICE BUSINESS | PUBLIC VERSION

Mid-project observations from a live commercial review | Public version

Prepared by Arrington Consultancy

WHY I GOT INVOLVED

I am now roughly halfway through the work with the business. The original brief was to review the website. It quickly became clear that I could not do that without understanding the business behind it: what the website was meant to achieve, who it was speaking to and what should happen when somebody made an enquiry.

Over the past two months I have attended meetings, reviewed shared drives and document systems, read operational reports and project papers, spoken with people involved in the business and followed live discussions about customers, systems and future plans. The more I looked, the clearer it became that the website was not the main problem. It was simply the first place where a wider issue became visible.

These are findings from the middle of a review: what I have seen, what the evidence supports and what I believe needs to change next.

THE REAL ISSUE

The clearest issue I have seen is a lack of clarity, direction and accountability. There is no shortage of ideas, effort or genuine care for customers. The problem is that projects can move forward before the destination, owner and expected result have been agreed. When that happens, staff fill in the gaps, decisions are interpreted differently and the next priority arrives before the last one is finished.

How does this win, support or retain more customers through the business?

That is the question I kept coming back to during website discussions, CRM conversations, AI meetings and document reviews. Sometimes the answer was obvious. Often it was not. It should become the commercial test for major projects, because once the destination is clear, priorities become easier, meetings become shorter and investment decisions become much harder to drift away from.

THE WEBSITE WAS THE FIRST WARNING

The website work began after the original supplier had already spent roughly a year developing a Squarespace site and repeatedly waiting for content, decisions and useful feedback. I then developed a separate Manus site as part of the review. The Manus build was not simply a prettier homepage. It included CRM integration and considerably more capability than the old live website.

To force a clear decision, I produced a detailed comparison workbook between the Manus build and a competitor site. It broke the proposed changes into individual decisions, gave the owner a yes or no box against every line and ended with an overall approval and signature section. It was deliberately built so that nothing could later be treated as already agreed. It received no meaningful feedback.

Later, the owner shared an AI response recommending Squarespace for the public website, Manus for bespoke AI, the current CRM and a shared intranet. I was then told Manus was the wrong platform for the public site, so I stopped that route and rebuilt the site in Squarespace. Shortly afterwards, before the Squarespace rebuild had been allowed to settle, attention moved again towards a new AI project and a potential funding opportunity.

None of those ideas was necessarily wrong. The problem was that the decision was inferred rather than made. The website did not suffer because somebody made one terrible decision. It suffered because decisions never quite became decisions.

THE CRM IS THE CLEAREST OPERATIONAL EXAMPLE

The CRM implementation review records unresolved issues around manual lead creation, pipeline progression, reporting, notifications and duplicate contacts. Those are not my assumptions; they are recorded within the business's own review.

Across several team meetings, staff repeatedly expressed frustration with the new CRM and asked whether they could return to the old system. They also said they had not received enough training and found the new system difficult to use. That does not prove the wrong CRM was purchased. It does prove that it has not been embedded. A new system only improves a business when the people using it understand it, trust it and use it consistently. At the moment, that is not happening.

LEADS ARE NOT VISIBLE ENOUGH

The staff messaging group gave live examples of the problem. In one customer enquiry, the owner asked whether one email had been sent and the follow-up then abandoned. A team member could see only one follow-up in the enquiry email trail and could not confirm whether further contact had happened through a direct message. The full communication history had to be checked with the responsible team member the following morning.

In another case, a customer had made an enquiry earlier in the year, but the details were held in the old records. The owner had to ask who the responsible team member was, and the team then had to reconstruct the contact history because the customer was continuing to message the owner directly. The evidence does not prove either customer was ignored. In fact, one record showed that follow-up had happened. What it proves is that the business could not immediately see the full history, who owned the enquiry or what the next action should be.

If a customer journey is spread across an old system, email, direct messages and individual staff knowledge, the business is relying on people remembering rather than on a controlled process. That is a visibility and accountability problem, and it creates a clear risk that a valuable enquiry becomes harder to manage than it needs to be.

INFORMATION IS NOT YET MANAGEMENT INFORMATION

There is a large amount of information inside the business. I have seen partner documents, contracts, commission information, operational files, CRM work and staff spreadsheets. The information exists. What is missing is one clear and trusted management view.

When I asked for figures covering enquiries, proposals, confirmed work and partner performance, I was shown separate staff spreadsheets using different colours, formats and keys understood mainly by the people who created them. That is not a criticism of the staff. They have built practical ways to keep work moving. The issue is that the data is personal rather than organisational.

A manager should be able to answer basic commercial questions quickly: how many live enquiries are open, who owns each one, where enquiries are being lost, which referral partners are producing qualified enquiries and confirmed work, which service lines generate the strongest return and how well enquiries convert into customers. Those answers should not depend on locating the right spreadsheet or finding the one person who understands its colour key.

MEETINGS NEED TO BECOME DECISIONS

The meetings I attended were positive, energetic and full of ideas. The conversation was useful. The weakness was what happened afterwards. A useful meeting should finish with a clear decision, one owner, one deadline and an agreed result. The next meeting should begin by checking whether it happened.

A clear decision, one owner and a deadline are what make progress stick. Without it, different people leave with different interpretations, open actions drift and the next opportunity starts competing with work that has never been finished. The website project shows exactly what happens when direction is implied rather than agreed. The same risk now exists around CRM, AI and funding.

WHAT THE BUSINESS ALREADY HAS

> *There is a business here with substance. I have seen staff profiles, live partner agreements, detailed policies, videos, operational knowledge and people working hard to support customers. The draft website work also demonstrated a clear personal service promise and stronger human trust than many competing service sites. Those are real assets, not polite filler.*
>
> *The business has substance, but it is not being held together tightly enough. Good people are working across different systems, spreadsheets and conversations without one consistent commercial rhythm. That creates noise, duplication and avoidable risk. These are solvable problems.*

WHAT NEEDS TO CHANGE NEXT

1. Agree the direction

The business needs one clear commercial direction for the next 12 months, supported by a longer-term plan. Every major project should be measured against it. If something does not help win, support or retain more customers through the business, it should not become a priority without a very good reason.

2. Get the CRM working

Before adding more technology, the existing CRM needs to be made usable. That means staff training, agreed workflows, clear ownership and one complete customer record. Staff feedback needs to shape the operating process, because the system will only work if the people using it understand what is expected and why.

3. Make every lead visible

Every live enquiry should have one visible owner, one complete communication history and one clear next action. The business should not have to reconstruct a customer journey through email trails, old records and personal messaging conversations.

4. Create one commercial dashboard

The business needs one simple monthly view covering enquiries, proposals, confirmed work, conversion rates, partner performance, service-line performance and team workload. The purpose is not to create more paperwork. It is to make sure the business is making decisions from the same facts.

5. Tighten accountability

Every meeting should end with the decision, the owner, the deadline and the expected result. That simple discipline would remove a large amount of uncertainty and stop good ideas becoming another open conversation.

6. Finish before starting again

The website needs an agreed scope and a final decision. The CRM needs embedding. Reporting needs standardising. Only then should new systems or larger AI projects be allowed to pull attention away. The business does not need another large project before it has extracted the value from the work already underway.

FINAL THOUGHTS

This is a mid-project view from somebody who has spent enough time inside the business to see a pattern. The business does not need more ideas at this point. It needs clarity, direction and accountability.

The second half should be about finishing what has started, making the important numbers visible and making sure every decision has an owner. That would give the people already working hard inside the business a much better chance of delivering the results the business is capable of.
The accompanying 90-Day Action Plan turns these findings into 11 practical actions, with owners, deadlines and clear evidence of completion to be agreed with the client team.